

ferent protocols in use. There have been several attempts to create a unified standard for instant messaging: IETF's SIP (Session Initiation Protocol) and SIMPLE (SIP for Instant Messaging and Presence Leverage), PRIM (Presence and Instant Messaging Protocol), and the open XML-based XMPP (Extensible Messaging and Presence Protocol). Attempts at creating a unified standard for the major IM providers has failed as each continues to use its own proprietary protocol.

There are a number of tools available off the Net for the sole purpose of messaging. The popular ones like Yahoo! Messenger and MSN Messenger can be downloaded from their respective Web sites for free. Apart from these, you also have Windows Messenger, which is almost exactly the same as the MSN IM client. A few multi-protocol clients such as iChat, Miranda and Trillian exist. These clients can support several of the popular chat clients such MSN and ICQ at the same time.

ICQ was the world's first IM computer program, and with over 300 million downloads, ICQ has been the most popular download at download.com for seven consecutive years.



A typical MSN messenger chat window



ICQ-One of the world's earliest chat clients